April 29

Getaway day. I'm scratching at drafts of some of the 14 speeches I'll be giving in Europe. We had a Cabinet Council meeting, another on the tax simplification plan. We're making some progress. Then a short meeting with our three head negotiators who are home on recess from the Geneva arms talks. Nothing much to report. . .

I hope I'm not being too optimistic but it seems there are a few signs that the Bitburg issue may be turning . . .

9:25 p.m.: A statement to the press before boarding Marine I on our way to Bonn. We tried something new for jet lag. There is a six hour time change so we took off at 10 p.m. AF I Washington time, it was already 4 a.m. Wednesday in Bonn. The flight was seven hours and 25 minutes. We got on board and went right to bed. I won't say we slept well but got a fair amount of shut eye. We also set our clocks to Bonn time, so in effect we were going to bed at 4 a.m. and due to arrive at 11:25 a.m. It worked. We were met by Ambassador and Mrs. Burns and Foreign Minister and Mrs. Genscher. Then we boarded Marine I and helicoptered to Schloss Gymnisch, the castle now used as a guest house by the German government. We had stayed there on our 1982 visit. . . .

As the time for my visit to the cemetery approached, the drumbeat of criticism got more and more strident, some of it implying that my refusal to cancel the trip proved I was anti-Semitic and pro-Nazi. No one, I think, was more unhappy with my determination to go ahead with the visit—she'd call it stubbornness—than Nancy.

Contrary to some of the speculation about her, Nancy only rarely tried to influence me when I was president. But on